Fridge Magnets

01 What holds a magnet to the fridge?



The magnet and steel door pull toward each other.

Look closer. Look at the magnet holding the paper drawing.

A little explanation. The magnet and the steel in this fridge door pull toward each other. The pull helps the magnet stay put. It can act through a thin piece of paper; the paper does not have to be magnetic.

Try this. Point to the magnet, the paper, and the steel door. Tell which two pull toward each other.

02 Will it stick to every surface?



Wood and plastic do not hold the magnet.

Look closer. The magnet rests at the bottom of the wood board.

A little explanation. Magnets stick to some metals, including iron and many kinds of steel. They do not stick to wood, plastic, paper, or cloth. Aluminum foil and copper do not stick to an ordinary fridge magnet either.

Try this. With Big nearby, predict and try a few fridge magnets on a fridge door or steel cookie sheet and a tray of paper, a plastic lid, wood, aluminum foil, and a steel paperclip. Notice what sticks and what slides. Keep magnets away from screens, cards with stripes, and mouths.

03 How far can the pull reach?



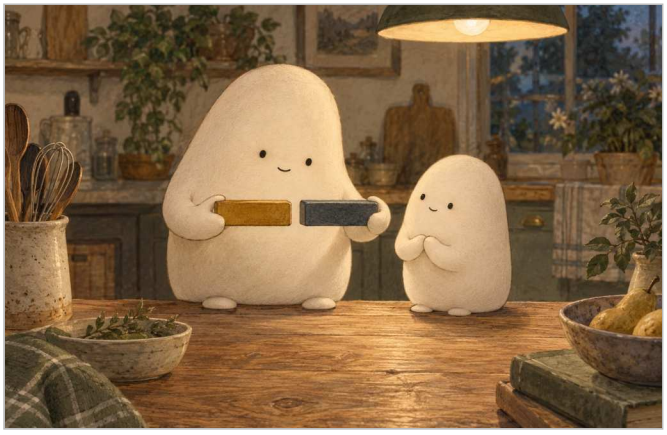
Closer makes the pull stronger.

Look closer. Look for the tiny gap beside the paperclip.

A little explanation. A magnetic pull can act across a gap. The closer the magnet is, the stronger the pull. Farther away, it gets weaker. Different magnets and objects can give different results.

Try this. With Big beside you, slowly move a magnet toward a steel paperclip on a tray. Use a ruler or finger-widths to compare the gap where it first moves. Lift the paperclip a little with the magnet, then gently draw them apart over the tray until it lets go.

04 Can two magnets push apart?



Turning a magnet can change a pull to a push.

Look closer. Look at the two ends facing each other.

A little explanation. Two magnets can pull together or push apart. Turning one magnet can change which ends face each other, changing the pull to a push.

Try this. With Big, turn one of two large magnets around and notice whether they pull together or push apart.